

THIS IS TECHNOLOGY, CULTURE AND SCIENCE WITH A DIFFERENCE, AND THAT DIFFERENCE IS USUALLY ENOUGH TO MAKE MOST NORMAL PEOPLE GO "WTF?"

This month in ALT:

This month, we take a look at how ESA (European Space Agency) tech is changing our world, then we highlight some cool gadgets in Desire, review some pop culture in Temptation and much more.



Eco friendly mining

This is a new approach of moving Ethereum from a proof-of-work model to a proof-of-stake model, where digital currencies use investment in hardware and energy as a proxy for the proof-of-work promises to reduce the energy consumption during cryptocurrency mining. <http://dgit.in/cryptoe>

WHAT'S NEW

The productivity paradox

Almost as soon as personal computers began to be made available in offices in the 1990s, experts began to question if these machines improved employee productivity. Experts at that time pointed out that white collar productivity had plateaued, and that higher ups in the company were not at all confident that employees could be made more productive by throwing computers at them. Studies supported these observations with one finding that noted computers contributed to only a 0.2 percent increase in output of companies between 1987 to 1993. Another early study indicated that computers actually increased the workload, and reduced time available for other tasks. Yet another



study showed that a company that fired off support typing staff after giving employees computers, had to hire more employees at higher salaries, as

these employees no longer had the support staff and were doing all the work themselves, and in the end wound up paying more for getting the same amount of work done. Now, a survey of various studies indicates that offices are suffering from an exponential increase in email threads, where employees are spending more time talking about work, than actually working. <http://dgit.in/ppdox>

The story behind Einstein's famous photo

This is possibly the most enduring and endearing image of Albert Einstein, taken on 14 March, 1951 on the day the physicist turned 72. A party was held at the Institute for Advanced Study in Princeton, where Einstein was working at that time, and the paparazzi had gathered outside the venue to get a quote from the physicist. The paparazzi were prompting Einstein to smile for the cameras, while he was

sitting in a vehicle sandwiched between his wife and the director of the institution.



Einstein was slightly irritated by the paparazzi, so as a spontaneous act of rebellion, stuck out his tongue instead

of smiling. Arthur Sasser, one of the paparazzi captured the now iconic photo. However, it was not the photographer that made this image famous, it was Einstein himself who liked the image so much that he ordered copies of it and then sent them out to colleagues, acquaintances and friends. He also gave away signed copies of the photo, one of which sold in 2009 for \$74,324.

<http://dgit.in/einpho>



Google career certificates

Google with Coursera has an ambitious new plan to help individuals get access to high paying and high growth jobs, through career certificates that provide students with the skills or qualifications needed to bridge the gap in their resumes, without the need for a degree. <http://dgit.in/googcc>



Memory of Mankind

The Memory of Mankind project is an attempt at making a time capsule to "preserve the knowledge about present human civilization from oblivion and collective amnesia", where people can contribute their memory and experiences that are preserved in tablets in a salt mine. <http://dgit.in/momp>



Ghost countries

Over 6.5 million Europeans live in countries that are not officially recognised by anyone else, most of these were the consequence of the USSR breaking apart. Here is a snapshot into the daily lives of the people who are living in constant uncertainty, and without security or benefits. <http://dgit.in/ghostcountries>